

The 6:15

TUESDAY · SEPTEMBER 29, 2026

NO. 21

THE BOARD

CALENDAR · NEXT 10 DAYS

Tue 9/29, 8:00a/10:00a ET	July Case-Shiller HPI (8a); Sept Conference Board Consumer Confidence & Aug JOLTS (10a)
Tue 9/29, 8:00p ET	Yankees host Red Sox, ALWC Gm 1, Yankee Stadium (NBC) — start time now confirmed
Wed 9/30, 8:30a ET	August PCE price index (BEA) — first inflation print since the Sept. 16 hike
Thu 10/1, after close	Nike FQ1 2027 earnings; consensus \$0.44 EPS / \$11.33B rev, 23 analysts (Alphastreet)
Fri 10/2, 8:00p ET	Northwestern hosts Penn State (3-1) at new Ryan Field — venue debut
Mon 10/5	Knicks preseason opens at Philadelphia

Standing: FOMC next meets Oct. 27-28, priced 65%-72% odds of a second 2026 hike (CME FedWatch and trackers, up from ~30% pre-September). Funding runs on the Dec. 11 continuing resolution, passed 370-48/90-6 before the FY26 close — no Sept. 30 shutdown risk. OPEC+'s October JMMC date still unconfirmed [continuity]. SpaceX's Starship Flight 14 reached orbit for the first time Monday, delivered 26 Starlink V3 satellites, then returned early after one orbit [NEW, resolves yesterday's pending window; see Technology]. Nvidia launched an Open Agent Safety Platform (OpenShell + Sentry) Sept. 28, backed by Anthropic, Arm, Microsoft, Oracle and SpaceX — not OpenAI [NEW; see Technology].

METRICS · ET UNLESS NOTED

Brent / WTI / spread	\$105.31-\$107.82 (no settle reconciled) / \$93.16 close-\$94.44 intraday (+2.2%) (unreconciled) / ~\$11-13
2y / 10y / 30y	4.94% (Mon close) / 5.24% (-1bp, 2007-high) / 5.56% (+4bp, fresh 2004-high)
DXY	101.36 (+0.16%), near 2-mo high; +1.94% 1mo, +3.67% 12mo
S&P / Nasdaq futures / VIX	-0.26% / -0.44% (premarket) vs QQQ +0.13% intraday (diverging) ; VIX 14.87 (Mon close)
Gold	\$4,141.32, -2.95% w/w, 7-week low

Asia / Europe closes	Nikkei 65,878 (-0.73%, snaps 5-session streak); Hang Seng ~24,510 (Fri, stale). FTSE 10,684.88 (-0.10%); DAX 25,374.42 (-0.13%); CAC 8,078.48 (+0.01%), all Mon close
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Retail gas (AAA)	\$4.4768/gal as of 9/28 (not reconfirmed today)
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No single Brent/WTI settle reconciled across sources this morning; equity-futures and cash-tech reads (QQQ) also diverge intraday — treat both complexes as directional pending the cash open. Fed funds target remains 3.75%-4.00% following the Sept. 16 hike; today's yield/dollar moves are being read against that level, not against any change to it.

HORMUZ COUNTERS

Transits	1 on Sept. 20 vs. 85/day pre-crisis baseline (IMF PortWatch, still the most recent published day)
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Vessels holding	233 AIS-visible, 02:49 UTC Sept. 28 (Windward/straits.live) — within the noisy 177-243 band of the past week
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War-risk premia	~10% of hull value fleet-wide; ~\$10M per transit on a \$100M tanker vs. ~\$250K pre-conflict (Howden Re/Marsh/S&P Global range, unchanged)
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Crisis Pressure	"Extreme" band, rising over 24h, transit deviation the top contributor (straits.live Hormuz Index — single-sourced, flagged)
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Transit counts (PortWatch, lagged), stranded-vessel counts (AIS, same-day volatility) and war-risk premia (insurance-market reporting, periodic) measure different things over different windows and vendors; never averaged or differenced here. See Iran & Hormuz below for the Sept. 23 Cape Dao attack, disclosed this run.

TRANSACTIONS

Yankees	Host Red Sox, ALWC Gm 1, tonight 8:00p ET; record 93-68
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Knicks	Training camp opened Sept. 29; no personnel moves
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Northwestern	No reported moves in the last 24 hours
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LEAD

IRAN — SEQUENCING, NOT SUBSTANCE

Waltz says Tehran wanted sanctions relief up front; Araghchi says he never saw the real offer — and Washington's answer is due today

The story hardened into a dispute over facts, not just positions. On CNN's "State of the Union" and NBC's "Meet the Press" Sunday, US Ambassador to the UN Mike Waltz gave the first detailed US account of what Trump actually rejected: Iran's seven-day Hormuz-reopening proposal, submitted through mediators Sept. 16, asked for sanctions relief and access to "billions in frozen assets" before any nuclear negotiation began — "everything up front, with a promise that they would then talk." Waltz called it "a pretty cynical attempt to put something on the table that they knew was unacceptable." [fact] That reframes Trump's rejection as a dispute over sequencing — who moves first — rather than a flat refusal to engage, which is a materially different read than Sunday's "doomsday war" framing alone suggested. [read]

Separately, Axios and CNN reported Monday that Trump is privately willing to grant sanctions relief and release frozen funds as part of an eventual deal — but only after Iran delivers "concrete progress" on the nuclear file. [fact] That is close to the destination Iran says it wants; the fight is over which side moves first and what counts as proof.

Araghchi pushed back directly on Waltz's account in the same "Meet the Press" segment, saying Iran had offered to open the Strait if the US released frozen assets and allowed Iranian oil sales — and suggesting Waltz had not read, or had not been shown, the actual proposal. "There has been no change whatsoever in Iran's positions," he said. [fact, disputed] The two sides are describing versions of the same trade that sound similar in substance but are being presented as irreconcilable in order — the kind of gap that is usually closable through mediators if both governments want it closed, and is usually presented as unbridgeable in public when they don't yet.

The forward-looking piece is what makes today load-bearing: Qatari mediators met separately with Araghchi in New York and with US officials Monday, and Araghchi said he expects an official US response "hopefully" by Tuesday — today, while this issue is being read. [fact] Nothing in the physical Hormuz counters has moved on any of this (Board); what has moved is price, and inconsistently. Brent gave back part of Monday's rejection-driven spike, easing toward \$105 from Monday's \$106.89-\$107.82 range, while WTI pushed further, up 2.2% intraday to \$94.44 — a divergence that most plausibly reflects thin, pre-settlement positioning ahead of the response rather than a clean read on physical risk. [read] The 10-year eased a basis point to 5.24% but remains at a 2007-era high; the 30-year pushed to a fresh 2004-era high at 5.56%. Equity futures were softer (S&P -0.26%, Nasdaq 100 -0.44%) even as tech (QQQ) traded higher intraday on semiconductor strength — a market pricing neither a clean de-escalation nor a clean hardening, more consistent with positioning uncertainty than conviction either way. [read]

The second-order stakes are real: the Fed is already priced at 65%-72% odds of a second 2026 hike at the Oct. 27-28 FOMC, up from roughly 30% before September, sitting on top of the Sept. 16 hike and one day ahead of Wednesday's August PCE print — the first inflation read since that hike. An oil-price move in either direction today, on the back of whatever Washington's answer turns out to be, lands directly inside that window. Three inputs — today's Iran response, this morning's Case-Shiller/Consumer Confidence/JOLTS batch, and tomorrow's PCE — now compound within 48 hours, each capable of moving the other's read on Fed policy before the market has settled on any of them individually.

What to watch for a genuine signal, as opposed to another round of dueling readouts: whether today's US response addresses sequencing directly (an interim or partial step, rather than an up-front/all-at-once framing on either side) and whether Tehran's public reaction matches Araghchi's private channel or reverts to Sunday's "doomsday war" register. A response that ignores the sequencing question entirely would be the more bearish outcome for oil and duration alike, since it would suggest neither side is actually negotiating the gap Waltz and Araghchi both just described in public.

POLITICS

China confirmed Monday the two-month US-China trade truce runs to Jan. 10; new detail since Friday's summit wrap-up shows the tariff relief is bigger than first disclosed — a "30-for-30" framework under which each side cuts tariffs on \$30B of the other's non-sensitive goods, \$60B combined (coal, agricultural products and financial-institution branch licensing from the US side; toys, car seats and holiday decorations from China's), double Friday's initial \$30B-total figure. [DEVELOPING] A bilateral AI-incident communication channel gets a follow-up dialogue in late November. Rare-earth and semiconductor tech-control disputes remain unresolved; Taiwan and Ukraine were raised but produced no deliverable. [fact] Worth flagging against Thursday's Nike print (Business, below): the truce's goods list leans toys and holiday goods, not footwear or apparel — it does little to touch Nike's actual tariff exposure, which is concentrated in Vietnam, not China. [read] The broader read: a truce that gets quietly bigger between its announcement and its written confirmation is a mildly constructive signal for the two governments' working relationship heading into the November AI dialogue, even though neither side has disclosed that dialogue's actual agenda yet.

ECONOMICS

Today's data is a warm-up for Wednesday's load-bearing print: July Case-Shiller home-price data at 8:00a ET, then September Conference Board Consumer Confidence and August JOLTS job openings at 10:00a, with Fed speakers scattered through the day and the API's weekly crude inventory read after the close. No consensus forecast for today's Consumer Confidence or JOLTS prints had been published as of this writing — flagged rather than estimated. [flag] Context: August's Confidence reading itself undershot, falling 0.8 points to 89.4 against a 90.3 forecast, the kind of miss that would ordinarily argue for easier policy but is instead landing inside a hiking cycle being driven by oil-linked inflation, not labor-market strength — the JOLTS print is being watched less for its own signal than for whether it gives the Fed room to treat Wednesday's PCE print as noise or as confirmation. [read] A soft JOLTS alongside a hot PCE would put the Committee in the same bind it faced heading into September — hiking into weakening labor demand because energy-driven inflation leaves it little choice — while a firm JOLTS would at least let hawks argue the economy can absorb another hike without a labor-market cost. None of it displaces Wednesday's 8:30a August PCE — the first inflation data since the Sept. 16 hike and the last before the Oct. 27-28 FOMC, where hike odds (65%-72%, CME FedWatch and trackers) have already moved on commentary and the oil complex well ahead of the number itself.

BUSINESS

Nike reports FQ1 2027 after Thursday's close on a now cross-verified consensus: \$0.44 EPS and \$11.33B revenue across 23 analysts (Alphastreet), down 11% and 3% y/y respectively — the

estimate range runs \$0.38-\$0.50 EPS, \$11.09B-\$11.55B revenue, and the consensus EPS figure has drifted down 2.2% over both the past 30 and 90 days. That is a materially firmer basis than Monday's single-sourced number. Nike cleared its prior-quarter bar by 54%; nothing this run points to a repeat or a miss either way. [fact] The tariff line is the one to watch inside the print: Nike sources roughly half its footwear from Vietnam (46% tariff rate) versus 18% from China, and has been actively shifting China footwear sourcing toward high-single-digits of the mix by fiscal year-end; the company has previously guided to a \$1B gross tariff hit and raised its FY26 margin-headwind estimate from roughly 75 basis points to 120. [fact] None of that is touched by Monday's China truce (Politics, above), since that deal's goods list is toys and holiday goods, not apparel or footwear. [read] With the margin headwind already guided up once this fiscal year, the call to watch Thursday is whether management raises it again or holds the 120-basis-point figure — a repeat increase would be the first hard evidence that the Vietnam-sourcing shift isn't landing on the timeline the company laid out.

TECHNOLOGY

Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang unveiled the Open Agent Safety Platform Sept. 28, pairing OpenShell — which lets developers "formally verify an agent has enough authority to do its job and no more" by sandboxing it and turning its instructions into a verifiable access policy — with Sentry, a new monitoring layer running on Nvidia's BlueField-4 DPUs that can "quarantine a suspicious agent in milliseconds." [NEW] Anthropic, Arm, Microsoft, Oracle and SpaceX have backed the open-source platform; OpenAI has not signed on, a split worth watching given OpenAI's own agent was the source of the August Hugging Face breach that the platform is

explicitly positioned against — the industry's leading model lab sitting outside the safety consortium other labs and its own infrastructure supplier are building. [fact/read] The commercial logic for Nvidia is straightforward: agent-safety tooling on its own silicon is a new reason for enterprises to buy BlueField DPUs alongside GPUs, not just a goodwill gesture. [read] The backer list disclosed so far (Anthropic, Arm, Microsoft, Oracle, SpaceX) reads as cloud-and-infrastructure-heavy rather than a full roster of frontier labs; whether Google DeepMind or Meta join, and on what terms, was not confirmed this run and is worth tracking as the platform moves from launch to adoption.

SpaceX's Starship Flight 14 reached orbit for the first time Monday and delivered 26 Starlink V3 satellites — the vehicle's first revenue-generating flight — before returning early after one orbit and splashing down in the Pacific north of Hawaii; one non-critical engine was lost during ascent but did not affect orbital insertion, and SpaceX is calling the flight a success on both primary objectives (reaching orbit, deploying payload). [NEW, resolves the pending launch window flagged Monday] No confirmed detail yet on why the flight ended after a single orbit rather than the planned duration, or on a Flight 15 date; flagged for next issue. [flag] No new frontier LLM releases confirmed overnight; September's wave (Claude Fable 5.1/Mythos 5.1, GPT-6 Astra, Gemini 3.8 Flash, Muse Spark 1.3 and 20-plus further late-month releases) is now continuity. [continuity]

GEOPOLITICS

Russian forces attacked 24 Sumy Oblast settlements over the past 24 hours with guided bombs, mortars and drones, injuring four; Ukrainian air defense downed one Zircon/Oniks anti-ship missile, two Iskander-M/S-400 ballistic missiles and 106 UAVs since Monday evening — a scale of overnight air activity toward the higher end of the past month's pattern. [NEW, fact] A separate strike on a Kyiv market killed two and injured four, with air-defense systems active over the capital Sept. 29; Russian strikes also hit Odesa infrastructure overnight, sparking a fire. [NEW, fact] Separately, Ukraine's Chess Federation protested Presidential-office adviser Mykhailo Podolyak's acceptance of a FIDE vice-president title alongside a former Russian minister — a minor item, included only because it is the kind of soft-power friction that tends to resurface once diplomatic tracks (Iran, Ukraine) are both live simultaneously and international bodies become another venue for the argument over normalization. No new confirmed Houthi-Saudi strike since the Sept. 26 intercept reported in issue No. 20; the Saudi-Pakistan-Turkey Makkah Joint Defense Agreement stands as last reported. [continuity]

IRAN & HORMUZ

The physical counters (Board) show no confirmed change tied to this week's diplomatic churn — transit data is still lagged to Sept. 20, and the vessel-holding count remains inside its noisy multi-week band. straits.live's proprietary Hormuz Index puts Crisis Pressure in its "extreme" band and rising, with transit deviation the top contributor — single-sourced, flagged. [flag] One disclosed detail

not previously in this brief: the bulk carrier MV Cape Dao, Antigua and Barbuda-flagged, was struck by two torpedoes roughly 2.5 nautical miles off Oman's Musandam coast on Sept. 23, killing a 26-year-old Indian crew member (identified as wiper Suraj Yadav) and prompting evacuation of the other 27 aboard by Oman's navy. [NEW, fact] Neither Iran nor the US has claimed responsibility, and unverified social-media claims that the vessel was coordinating with US authorities before the strike remain unconfirmed. That unclaimed-attack pattern is itself informative: combined with the previously undisclosed Sept. 14 Marine-casualty strike (issue No. 20) and the disputed second REMUS-drone claim, it points to a more active and less fully disclosed shadow war than the transit and vessel-holding counters alone capture — the diplomatic track (Lead) and the physical one are not obviously moving together this week.

SPORTS

Yankees	93-68; host Red Sox tonight, 8:00p ET, ALWC Gm 1, Yankee Stadium (NBC).
Knicks	No game; training camp opened Sept. 29; preseason opener Oct. 5 at Philadelphia.
Northwestern	2-1, no game since Sept. 25 loss at Indiana (29-23); hosts Penn State (3-1) Fri. 10/2, 8:00p, Ryan Field (venue debut).

Continuity. Cut from issue No. 20 as unmoved or resolved: the Yankees ALWC start-time flag (now confirmed 8:00p), the Hormuz methodology explainer (carried in Board note only), and the Sept. 14 Marine-casualty and REMUS-drone items (referenced but not re-detailed; no update since Monday). Not refreshed this run: today's European and Asian cash sessions (not yet closed as of writing), a same-day AAA gas read, and Fed speakers' specific remarks. Watch for next issue: Washington's promised response to Iran, due today; Wednesday's PCE print and its effect on Oct. 27-28 odds; the ALWC Gm 1 result; whether the 177-243 Hormuz vessel-count band resolves into a trend; and any attribution on the Cape Dao strike.

Unverified figures are marked in red above. No Brent/WTI settle was reconciled this morning;

VIX, AAA gas and the Hang Seng close are carried from the most recent confirmed print rather than today's session. Nothing was estimated or filled from memory.